

Swamp White Oak

Quercus bicolor



Origin

Native to the eastern and midwestern United States and southeastern Canada, especially in wet bottomlands, floodplains, and low-lying areas near rivers.

Look for

Turn a leaf over -- the pale, softly fuzzy underside contrasts sharply with the dark green top, a trait most other street oaks don't share.

IDENTIFICATION TIPS

- Leaf underside: pale, softly fuzzy, contrasting with dark green top.
- Leaf lobes: rounded, part of the white oak group (not bristle-tipped).
- Bark: flaky, papery gray-brown.
- Commonly confused with: northern red oak (swamp white oak's lobes are rounded, not pointed, and its acorns mature in one year, not two).

THROUGH THE SEASONS

Spring	Leaves emerge with a fuzzy, silvery underside still visible.
Summer	Leaves are dark green on top with a pale, soft underside.
Fall	Leaves turn yellow-brown to russet, often later than other oaks.
Winter	Flaky, papery gray-brown bark separates it from other oaks.

DID YOU KNOW

- It tolerates wet, poorly drained, low-oxygen soil better than almost any other oak, which is why cities increasingly plant it in stormwater tree pits and rain gardens.
- Its acorns mature in a single year (unlike red oak's two years) and are an important food source for wood ducks and other wetland wildlife.